



On the field, the Indian team showed enough grit to equalise after being a goal down, offering the local supporters some joy.

But off the pitch, Hyderabad fell short of demonstrating its potential as a prominent football venue, instead settling for reflected glory and political vaudeville.

The venue's shortcomings were glaring: insufficient water for volunteers during the pre-match rush, hundreds of spectators trespassing into the stands mid-game, and schoolchildren throwing bottle caps at journalists seated in a press box that's awkwardly placed at a 45-degree angle from the goalpost (**above**). The stadium was everything a venue should not be in a FIFA



NEELADRI BHATTACHARJEE

international friendly.

The draw at full-time marked a winless calendar year for India for the first time since 2006 (with at least five matches played), closing a putrid chapter for Indian football, both on and off the field, in the historic City of Nizams.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee

Colaco golazo

Liston Colaco (**below**) stood on the touchline, caressing the ball like a baby. His expression radiated the joy of unbounded relief and achievement.

The Mohun Bagan Super Giant forward was celebrating a goal that showcased the quality and class of a top international football striker.

For the 25,000 fans gathered to cheer their team against Jamshedpur FC at the Salt Lake Stadium, Colaco had delivered a brilliant moment to savour.

He weaved through Jamshedpur FC's defensive setup with

the deftness and class that led many fans to draw comparisons with none other than Lionel Messi.

Known for his speed and creativity, Colaco had struggled for form earlier in the season.

However, the goal — where he outsmarted five Jamshedpur FC defenders before finishing with a precise angular shot — seemed to have dispelled doubts about his fitness and form.

The goal went viral online, with many users hailing it as "magical" and comparing his "stunning" skill to that of some of the best strikers in the world.

"Not many players have this kind of talent. I am really happy to see him score that fine goal," said his coach, Jose Molina, after the match.

Receiving praise from Molina, who previously served as the sporting director of the Spanish football federation, is a significant achievement for Colaco, given Molina's exposure to the best of international football.

"Liston had many chances so far in the league but had to wait until the eighth match to score. Hopefully, this goal will encourage him to go for more in the coming matches," Molina added, while cautioning his "talented" winger to be more consistent.

Amitabha Das Sharma



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